

Session 25: Jacob's Silence

Key Takeaways

- In the aftermath of Shechem's crime, Yaaqov's silence and inaction creates a void that his sons fill with vengeful violence.
- The biblical authors tell the story of Yaaqov's sons' treachery with links to the flood narrative, but this is a nightmare version of God's just judgment and reconciliation through covenant.

Yaaqov's Sons Deceive the Men of Shechem

⁸ And Khamor spoke with them, saying,
"Sh'khem, my son, he has deep affection for your daughter.
Please, give her to him as a wife.

⁹ And become in-laws with us,
and give us your daughters,
and you may take our daughters for yourselves,
¹⁰ and dwell with us, and the land will be before you.
Dwell, and trade in it, and take possession of it."

¹¹ And Sh'khem said to her father and to her brothers,
"May I find favor in your eyes.
And whatever you tell me, I will give it.
¹² Make the bride-price and gift much for me,
and I will give it, according to what you tell me,
and give to me the young woman as a wife."

¹³ And the sons of Yaaqov responded with deception ,
to Sh'khem and to Khamor his father,
because he had defiled Dinah their sister .

¹⁴ And they said to them,
"We are not able to do this thing,
to give our sister to a man who has a foreskin,
because this is disgraceful to us.
¹⁵ Only on this condition will we give consent to you:
If you become like us,
by circumcising for yourselves every male .
¹⁶ Then we will give our daughters to you,

and we will take your daughters for ourselves,
and we will dwell with you, and we will become one people.

17 And if you do not listen to us, to get circumcised ,
then we will take our daughter,
and we will go.”

18 And their words were good
in the eyes of Khamor,
and in the eyes of Sh’khem son of Khamor,
19 and the young man did not delay in doing this thing,
because he took pleasure in the daughter of Yaaqov.
Now, he had honor, more than all of the house of his father.

20 And they spoke to the men of their city, saying,
21 “These men are peaceful with us,
and they will dwell in the land, and they will trade in it,
and the land, look, it is wide of hand before them,
and we will take their daughters for ourselves as wives,
and we will give our daughters to them.

22 Only on this condition will the men consent to us ,
to dwell with us, to become one people ,
by circumcising for ourselves every male , just as they are circumcised .

23 Their herds and their possessions and all their cattle,
won’t it become ours?
Only let us consent to them ,
so they can dwell with us.”

24 And they listened to Khamor and to Sh’khem his son,
everyone going out of the gate of his city,
and every male was circumcised ,
everyone going out of the gate of his city.

Genesis 34:8-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Yaaqov's Sons Murder the Men of Shechem

25 And it came about on the third day,
while they were in pain,
that the sons of Yaaqov took up,
Shim’on and Levi,
brothers of Dinah,
each his own sword ,
and they came upon the peaceful city,
and they murdered every male.

26 And **Khamor and Sh'khem his son**,
they murdered with the mouth of **the sword**,
and **they took Dinah** from **the house** of **Sh'khem**,
and they went out.

27 **The sons of Yaaqov** came over the slain bodies,
and they plundered the city,
because they had defiled their sister.

28 Their flocks and their cattle and their donkeys,
and whatever was in **the city**,
and whatever was in the field,
they took it,

29 and all their wealth,
and all their children,
and all their wives,
they took them captive **and they plundered**,
and all that was in the house.

30 And Yaaqov said to **Shim'on and to Levi**,
"You have brought trouble upon me,
by making me stink
among the dwellers of the land, among **the Canaanite and Perezite**.
And I'm just a few bodies,
and they will gather against me and **strike me**,
and **I'll be destroyed**, me and **my house**!"

31 And they said,
"Should he have done to **our sister** as a prostitute?!"

Genesis 34:25-31. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Exalted Men, Sexual Abuse, Angry Brothers, and a Flood of Violence

The sequence of this story is modeled on a condensed replay of the key stories in Genesis 4-9, from Cain's murder to the rising violence that results in a flood of death.

The story begins with a series of clear references to Genesis 6:1-4.

- Genesis 34:1-2: Dinah "the daughter ... born to Yaaqov went out to look upon the daughters of the land, and he saw her ... and he took her ... and he lay with her." // Genesis 6:1-2: "and daughters were born to them [humanity], and the sons of *elohim* looked upon the daughters of humanity, that they were good, and they took them for wives ..."

- Genesis 34:2: Shechem, son of Hamor (= “Donkey”), the Hivite (cf. Gen. 10:17) is an “exalted one in the land” (נשיא הארץ) // Genesis 6:1-2: “the sons of *elohim*,” that is, the host of the skies (see Gen. 2:1)
- Genesis 34:1: Dinah's (דינה) name means “Judgment” // Genesis 6:3: “My spirit will not abide/contend (ידון) with humanity forever.”

As a follow-up to the Genesis 6:1-4 patterns, the rest of the story develops the flood/covenant pattern and merges it with the Cain/sibling rivalry pattern from Genesis 4.

- Genesis 34:3: “he spoke to her heart” // Genesis 8:21: “God spoke to his heart”
- Genesis 34:7: “and they were pained (ויתעצבו) and hot anger was to them (ויהר להם), greatly” // Genesis 6:6: “And God was pained (ויתעצב) in his heart” // Genesis 4:5: “and hot anger was to Cain (ויהר לקין), greatly.”
- Genesis 34:15: “circumcision” (מול) + “the flesh/every male” (בשר / זכר) // Genesis 6:17, 9:11: the “flood” (מבול) “cut off all flesh” (יכרת כל בשר)
- Genesis 34:25-26: “and the sons of Yaaqov, Shimon and Levi, the brothers of Dinah, they murdered (ויהרגו) every male ... and they murdered (הרגו) Hamor and Shechem his son” // Genesis 4:8: “And Cain rose up against his brother and he murdered him” (ויהרגהו)

A Deceptive Covenant of Circumcision

In the first flood narrative, Noah offered a sacrifice that God accepted, so God made a covenant of peace with Noah and all living creatures. That narrative pattern was developed in the story of Genesis 16-17, where Abraham and Sarah abused their Egyptian slave to produce a child, and God brought a flood of judgment on Abraham's genitals as well as a sign of covenant mercy: circumcision.

Recall from Genesis 17 that circumcision was a sign of the covenant so that anyone not from Abraham's family line through Sarah could still be included in the covenant blessing by being circumcised. In other words, circumcision was the way for non-Israelites to be included within the family chosen for blessing.

What was given by God as a sign of judgment and hope to Abraham for abusing the Egyptian slave is now used by Abraham's great grandchildren as a deceptive weapon against the Canaanites. But the Canaanites are not innocent. Their leader Shechem is guilty of the heinous offense of abusing an Israelite woman.

Genesis 34:15 Instructor's Translation

... we will consent (נאות) to you, if you become like us in being circumcised (מול) ...

Genesis 17:11 NASB

And you shall be circumcised (מול) in the flesh of your foreskin, and it shall be the sign (אות) of the covenant between me and you.

What was given as a sign to include non-chosen lineages into the covenant is now being used as a ruse to destroy the non-chosen lineages.

Just as circumcision was divine judgment on Abraham's “instrument” of sin against Hagar the Egyptian, so now the sons of Yaaqov (“Deceiver”) use circumcision as a deceptive tool against Shechem, who used the same part of his body to “oppress” Dinah.

"In [Genesis] 17 the rite of circumcision was a sign (v. 11) of the unity of the covenant people and their separation from the rest of the nations. Circumcision was not limited to the seed of Abraham but was rather given as a sign of one's participation in the hope of God's promises to Abraham ... A thematic interplay between chapters 17 and 34 ... [T]he wordplay in the two chapters between the word sign (אֵימָה 17:11) and the consent (נִאֲמָה 34:15, 22-23) of the two families to live as one people ... Jacob and his family have continuously been characterized as those who attempted to carry out God's intentions by means of their own plans and schemes. On the surface, their plans worked reasonably well, though they always involved cunning and deceit to succeed. The writer does not wish to suggest that such plans represented God's own plans. On the contrary, Jacob's plans and those of his family are always depicted as the plans of those who were far ahead of God and his plans. Nevertheless, the ultimate purpose of these narratives is to show that in spite of the fact that such plans ran counter to God's own, they could not thwart the eventual success of his intentions."

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [*The Pentateuch as Narrative*](#). Zondervan Academic. 201-202.

Reflection Question

How does pointing out the links to the flood narrative help us understand the story of Yaaqov's sons' treachery?